

. . . if you're doing 'door-to-door sales work' . . .

. . . in the ACT.

In most other states the minimum age is 13, though interestingly in Tassie there's no minimum age whatsoever (which explains why Tasmania has so many 12-year-olds selling encyclopedias door to door).

Regardless of state-based laws, many employers have their own rules for employment age. McDonald's and KFC, for example, won't employ anyone under the age of 14 (or 15 for Victoria, where bizarrely they deem that teens need another year to mature).

Anyway, from the day I turned 14 I'd been working on getting a job at my local Woolworths (I'm so old it was called Safeway back then). I'd handed in my résumé, filled out the application form in advance, and had a few casual follow-ups with the store manager.

It worked. I scored a job!

In the . . . delicatessen?

I came in for my first shift and was introduced to the deli team. It turned out I was the only male staff member in a 10-strong team of women. Then I was given my uniform—a white butcher's jacket, a red bow tie and a paper hat. Seriously, I looked like one of the Village People.

Now, because I was a teenage boy, I was intensely interested in teenage girls . . . and the cutest girls at Safeway were the checkout chicks (a politically incorrect term, for sure).

My friend Matt also worked at Safeway, but he had the good fortune to be employed as a grocery boy (another politically incorrect term). That meant he got to flirt with the checkout chicks and do price checks for them.

Teehee-hee, aisle three price check, please . . . on condoms!

They never called me over the PA for a price check. I sat at the back of the store, wearing my little bowtie and paper hat, handling the salami. Or stuffing a chicken's butt. Or navigating the volatile emotions of the middle-aged women I worked with.